Antisemitism in contemporary Poland cannot be understood using Western European paradigms. The recrudescence of antisemitism in Western Europe has largely been driven by disaffected Muslims who failed to acculturate into the surrounding society and who are ostensibly protesting Israel's alleged transgressions toward Palestinian Arabs. Indigenous left-wing and liberal cultural elites have made common cause with these elements as have some of the extreme right-wing, which sought to legitimize their traditional antipathy toward Jews. However, modern-day Poland is an exceptionally homogenous country with only a negligible Muslim population (no more than 20,000, of whom some 2,000 are indigenous Tartars) and its influence on society is utterly marginal. Nevertheless, as Poland is integrated into the European Union, it has adopted an increasingly critical view of Israel. This tendency is also reflected in the Polish media, which is rather less supportive of Israel than it once was.[7] Thirty-five percent of those queried in the 2013 survey by the Center for Research on Prejudice agreed that "Israel is a country that does not flinch at anything to achieve its goals" (34% disagreed); 21% believed that the Israeli treatment of Palestinians does not differ from the way Hitler treated the Jews during World War II (59% disagreed).

Anti-Jewish hostility is, on occasion, vented on real Jews (as opposed to those merely accused of being Jews or Jewish lackeys) and Jewish property—including Jewish burial grounds. Most Poles (90%), at least according to the aforementioned CBR study (though one suspects that the number is higher), have never met a Jew. Therefore, antisemitism today has little to do with the concrete existence of Jews in Poland. That is so even though the Jewish community has an unusually high profile. If anything, Polish antisemitism (as well as philosemitism) is concerned primarily with dead Jews, not live ones.

Beyond traditional (theologically based) antisemitism, which is slowly losing ground, antipathy to Jews in present-day Poland must be understood above all through the prism of Polish society's ongoing and very painful confrontation with its own history. For more than twenty-five years now, history-conscious Polish society has been gripped by a bitter struggle over how to understand its own past—and how Jews figure into that story. Where Poland's approach to its own history is concerned, it would not be inappropriate to borrow a phrase from William Faulkner, who, in his *Requiem for a Nun*, characterized his native Mississippi as a place where "the past is never dead; it's not even past."

Until the disintegration of Communism, there was never any *Vergangenheitsbewältigung* in Poland and it was impossible to carry out any

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